

Xiaomi 14

Recreating Leica magic

After Vivo and Zeiss, OnePlus and Hasselblad, it is now time for Xiaomi and Leica with the latest flagship in the market, the Xiaomi 14. The smartphone comes with a beautiful metal and glass finish in a compact and handy package, and a lot more. In this review, I will talk about what I like about the Xiaomi 14, what I don't like about the smartphone, and finally, if you should spend your Rs xxx on the Xiaomi 14.

DESIGN

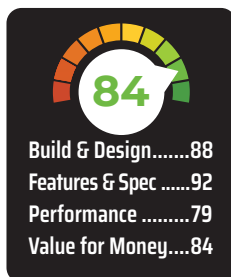
The design of the Xiaomi 14 has been one of my favourites in 2024 so far. The smartphone feels solid in the hand, and is compact. I am a sucker for compact smartphones and if we get a flagship in a compact package, it is all a person like me can ask for. At the back, we have the glass back, which has a matte finish in the black colour that I got for review, and there is also the "Jade Green" colour which has a much more glossy finish. The camera module is similar to last year's Xiaomi 13 Pro with the square module and the very subtle Leica branding.

Up front, we get a hole-punch flat display with super thin bezels and no chin, giving the smartphone a very premium look from up front. Now the bezels are so thin that while this is a 6.36-inch display, the Xiaomi 14 is almost the same size as the Google Pixel 8, which has a 6.2-inch display. Both the front and back glass panels are enclosed in a beautiful metal frame that gives the Xiaomi 14 a very premium in-hand feel.

DISPLAY

Coming to the display, here again the Xiaomi 14 performs pretty well. The Xiaomi 14 is claimed to offer up to 3,000 nits of peak brightness but that is a number we have seen being thrown

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around quite a lot this year. How good is it? Well, the Xiaomi 14, under absolutely bright sun, showcased a peak luminance of 970 nits, which is pretty good for any smartphone in any segment. This display is also very accurate at the same time. I

ran a colour checker analysis on the Xiaomi 14's display and the smartphone showcased an average DeltaE of 2.3 in the DCI-P3 colour space and an average DeltaE of 2.1 in the sRGB colour space, which is good in terms of how a smartphone's display should look like, but not at par with how accurate some of the recent smartphone's that I have tested recently are. We also get a 120Hz LTPO panel, which means that the display is also smooth and slick in terms of how it performs. Be it switching between apps, scrolling through menus, or high frame rate support on games, the Xiaomi 14 does it all very smoothly. So the display is good. It is sufficiently bright, extremely smooth, but isn't the most accurate in terms of the colour representation.

PERFORMANCE

Coming to performance, the Xiaomi 14 is powered by a Qualcomm Snapdragon 8 Gen 3 chipset paired with up to 16GB of RAM. Proper bleeding edge stuff. Not only on paper, in reality also the Xiaomi 14 performs really well. The smartphone showcased brilliant performance numbers. On AnTuTu, the Xiaomi 14 came ahead of rival devices like the Samsung Galaxy S24 or the OnePlus 12, but fell slightly short as compared to its fiercest rival, the Vivo X100 Pro. The story remains similar in other CPU-based benchmarks, where the Xiaomi 14 comes ahead of some rivals, but right behind some others.

In GPU-based benchmarks like 3DMark Wildlife Extreme, the Xiaomi 14 comes ahead of most of the competition like OnePlus 12, Samsung Galaxy S24, or the Vivo X100 Pro.

Now, while synthetic benchmarks are a good indicator of the smartphone's performance, it is not the whole picture. In day-to-day how the smartphone performs, how it heats, if the gaming experience is good and how much the device throttles, all of that is subject to daily usage. The Xiaomi 14, in almost all aspects, is a supreme performer. It is snappy, it is slick, and it doesn't heat up much, even if you go crazy with the camera of the smartphone.

Since this is a Leica co-developed camera, I have been playing around with it since the day I got my hands on the Xiaomi 14 and the smartphone doesn't heat up or throttle much, which is good. I ran the CPU throttle test also on the Xiaomi 14 to check how much the smartphone throttles, and the Xiaomi 14 throttled to xx percent of the performance.

Coming to software, this is one of the first smartphones that I have used with Xiaomi's new HyperOS UI, and while the changes are minimal, it is difficult to say how much of a difference it makes in the overall experience since the basic stuff remains the same. One annoyance that I have always faced with Xiaomi's software also remains is the amount of permissions and alerts that you have to go through while setting up the smartphone or while downloading new apps. The few seconds it takes to scan apps right after makes